J.J. Irani took over as MD of TISCO in July 1992 and Ratan became the company's chairman the following year. The metallurgist became Ratan's right-hand man and worked with him to implement his vision, complementing it with Irani's own academic brilliance and innovative thinking. The chairman 'led from the front', demanding daily reports which he read carefully. And in 1993–94, TISCO made a profit. Hussain declares, 'If you ask me what leadership is, I saw it in action.'

'The most touching thing about it was that everybody in the team was working for RNT,' he continues, adding that they were driven by the compulsive and powerful driving thought, 'We can't let him down.'

Faced with a crisis, Ratan implemented his restructuring programme most forcefully in TISCO. His strategy in the steel major rested on four pillars—cost-cutting, modernization, custom focus and overseas expansion.

At his first AGM as TISCO chairman on 22 July 1993, some two months after the appointment, Ratan laid out the company's Strategic Plan. He announced the need for TISCO to 'evolve a new strategy to meet the changed market situation'. He stated that the company would 'need to be far more market-driven to meet the challenges of the shift from a protected to a free, open market' and would 'also need to critically review its cost inputs and operations in order to become more competitive'.

He accorded priority to reduction of expenses. An early move in this direction was to cut dividends in 1992–93 as 'profits fell two-fifths to $41 million'. He then turned his attention to reversing the trend of the yearly rise in the production cost. Ratan challenged the management to achieve the 'impossible' in his own polite and unique way. 'He can be very persistent and persuasive in his subtle way. But the pressure can be intense. It is injected in small doses, but it rises with great rapidity leaving no option but to deliver,' Tridibesh Mukherjee remarks.

The AGM of July 1992 was followed by the company board meeting in Bombay. Following it, Ratan invited the senior functionaries of the company to a special dinner at the Chambers of Taj Mahal Hotel.

As the clock struck eight, Ratan walked in, dressed informally in a light-green shirt and blue trousers. He greeted everybody in his warm and polite way. He then got down to business. He elaborated how the years from 1991 had become a more difficult period for TISCO. On 17 January 1992, steel prices had been decontrolled. The import duty on steel had been reduced by an average of over 46 percentage points. Anyone could now import the